Local Pragmatics

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Introduction

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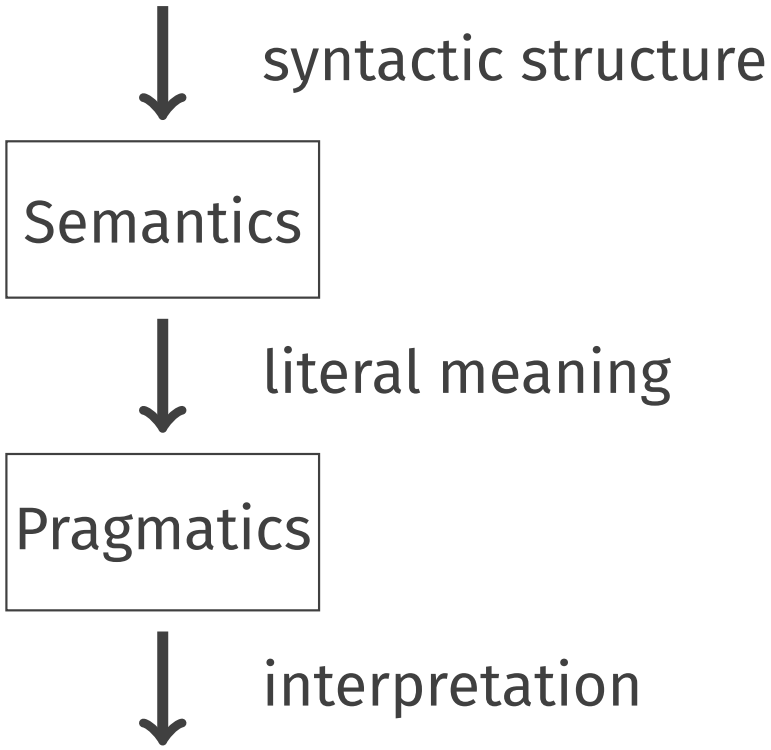
Goal

- Argue against the existence of certain "*pragmatic*" operators, using ellipsis tests a.o.
  - A for accommodation
  - R for diversity inferences [Blumberg and Goldstein, 2020]
- Provide an alternative to syntactization for cases of local pragmatics.

Traditional mapping from syntax to interpretation:



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- An inference is assumed to be generated by the pragmatics.
- This inference is discovered to "*intrude*" in the semantics.
- The locus of the inference is moved over to the semantics.
  - **operator approach:** an syntactically represented operator performs the "*pragmatic operation*"
  - **compositional approach:** the pragmatic operation is added as part of the rules of composition

Introduction

Scalar implicatures

(1) Some of the people smiled.
$\rightsquigarrow$ *not all of the people smiled.*

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⇝ *not all of the people smiled.*

Gricean pragmatic reasoning

- *some* literally means ∃
- speaker could have said the more informative *all*
- speaker has an opinion on whether *all people smiled* (opinionatedness)
- if speaker believes *all people smiled* were true, speaker would say it (cooperative).
- they didn't say *all people smiled*
- speaker doesn't believe *all*

⇝ global reasoning

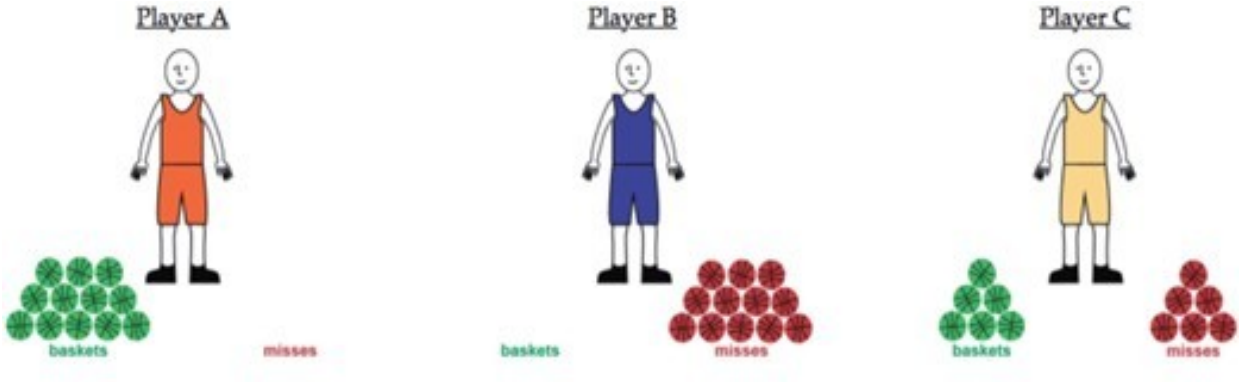
After Gricean reasoning has taken place, (2a) has the same interpretation as (2b).

(2) a. Some of the people smiled.

b. Some of the people but not all of the people smiled.

SIs intrude [Chierchia et al., 2012] !

(3) Exactly one player hit some of their shots. [Potts et al., 2016]
≈ *exactly one player hit some but not all of his shots*



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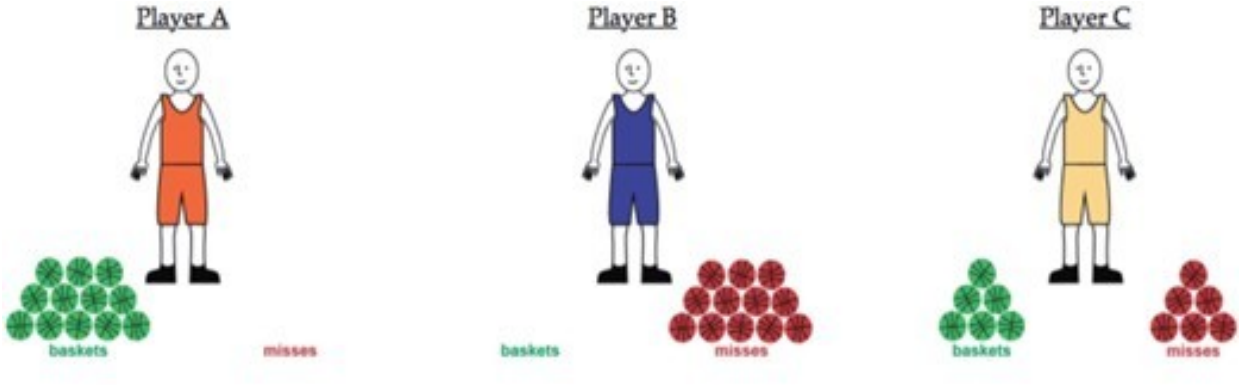

(4) Exactly one person hit all of their shots.

If SIs "*intrudes*" in the truth-conditions, they probably belongs to the literal meaning. Two possibilities:

(5) **Operator approach** [Chierchia et al., 2012]

a. Exactly one players O hit some of his shots.

b. O Some people smiled

(6) **Compositional approach** [Chierchia, 2004]
o $[\![\text{some}]\!] = (\exists, \{\neg\forall\})$

Three cases in point:

- Scalar Implicatures → O
- Accommodation → A
- Diversity Inferences → R [Blumberg and Goldstein, 2020]

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Introduction

Accommodation

Presuppositions are typically seen as conditions that must hold of the common ground prior to an utterance [Stalnaker, 1975].

(7) My llama is sick.
if hearer doesn't know I have a llama

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if hearer doesn't know I have a llama

(8) My brother is in town.

(9) a. My brother is in town

b. **Literal:** $[\![(9a)]\!]$ = [<u>I have a brother</u>] my brother is in town

Pragmatic theory of accommodation:

- Speaker conveyed a proposition undefined in some worlds of the common ground.
- If it is reasonable to do so, update the common ground to exclude the worlds where the presupposition is not met.

The effect of accommodation is tantamount to conjoining what was said with its presupposition.

(10) I have a brother and my brother is in town.

Accommodation intrudes as well! (a.k.a. **local accommodation**)

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(12) Why is Bob so irritable these days ?
Maybe he's trying to stop smoking.

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Maybe he's trying to stop smoking.

≈ *maybe he is a smoker and he's trying to stop*

Here too, there are two solutions:

- **Operator approach**
- **Compositional approach**

⇝ not clear to me that there is an official position on that in the literature on local accommodation
[Beaver and Krahmer, 2001, Heim, 1983]

An operator approach

(13) $[\![\mathrm{A}]\!]([\underline{p'}]\ p) = []\ p' \wedge p$

(14) a. I won't [A be interviewed by the CTO].

b. Why is Bob so irritable these days ?
Maybe [A he's trying to stop smoking].

Introduction

Diversity inferences

(15) The detective believes that either Ann or Sue stole the Monet painting.

⇝ *the detective isn't sure that Ann stole the Monet painting*

⇝ *the detective isn't sure that Sue stole the Monet painting*

a. # ... he furthermore believes that Ann stole it.

This inference intrudes as well [Blumberg and Goldstein, 2020]:

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(17) Exactly 2 of the 4 detectives are such that:

a. they believe it was Ann or Sue

b. they aren't certain it was Ann

c. they aren't certain it was Sue

This suggests an operator approach
[Blumberg and Goldstein, 2020]:

(18) Exactly 2 of the 4 detectives believe that R(either Ann or Sue that committed the crime.)

Introduction

Plot

Research Question

- Is there evidence that these syntactic operators exist ?
- Are local readings subject to the parallelism conditions on ellipsis?

Claim: Ellipsis preserves semantically contentful operators, even covert.

Covert generic operator

(19) One Monet sells for more than $3M.

a. **Episodic:** *there is a Monet that is worth more than $3M*

b. **Generic:** *in general, you get more than $3M for one Monet*

Covert generic operator

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(20) a. **Episodic:** one Monet sells for more than $3M.

b. **Generic:** GEN one Monet sells for more than $3M.

(21) _ The art appraiser thinks that one Monet sells for more than $3M.
_ Bill does too ; he's hoping to buy it.

(22) a. X [... OP ...]. Y did <... OP ...> too.

b. X [... ∅ ...]. Y did <... ∅ ...> too.

c. *X [... OP ...]. Y did <... ∅ ...> too.

d. *X [... ∅ ...]. Y did <... OP ...> too.

Observing non-parallel readings suggests the operator is not real[1].

[1] Or that it is parametrized

Accommodation

Accommodation

Accommodation and ellipsis

(23) "*take X out of Y*" presupposes "*X was in Y before*"

a. Did you take the rat out of its cage?

b. I didn't take the rat out of its cage.

c. If she took the rat out of its cage, we're doomed.

d. _ Was the rat in the cage?
_ I took it out of the cage.

(24) **Context:** *we're supposed to take the lab rat out of its cage, once a day. Otherwise, it feels stressed. Bill has been unreliable in performing this task.*

A: _ Last Monday, Bill didn't take the lab rat out of its cage.
B: _ On Wednesday as well, but that's just because I took it home on Tuesday and forgot to bring it back, so it wasn't in the cage at all that day.

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A: _ Last Monday, Bill didn't take the lab rat out of its cage.
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(25) Last Monday, [... ∅ ...]. On Wednesday as well, <... A ...>.

(26) a. On Monday, [he didn't take the lab rat out of its cage.]

b. On Tuesday as well, <he didn't A take the lab rat out of its cage.>

(27) a. $[\![(26a)]\!]$ = [<u>in-cage</u>] ¬take-out

b. $[\![(26b)]\!]$ = [] ¬ (in-cage ∧ take-out)

(28) _ In brigade A, no general circulated any of their battle plans to the foot soldiers prior to the confontation.
_ In brigade B as well, simply because the generals there had no battle plans.

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(29) In brigade A, [... ∅ ...]. In brigade B as well, <... A ...>.

Accommodation

Replies

Strictness of the parallelism requirement

Ellipsis allows mismatches between the elided phrase and its antecedent.

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(30) Syntactic mismatches

a. I didn't see anything but he did <see something>.

b. Everybody likes Jane's work.
She is the only one who doesn't <like her work>.

Strictness of the parallelism requirement

Ellipsis allows mismatches between the elided phrase and its antecedent.

(30) Semantic mismatches: ϕ-feature mismatch

a. I brought my llama. And you did <bring your llama> too.

b. Jeanne a parlé à son banquier et Marc aussi <a parlé à sa banquière>.
Jane has talked to POSS.M banker.M and Mark too <has talked to POSS.F banker.F>
"Jane talked to her (male) banker and Mark to his (female) banker."

(31) a. On Monday, [he didn't take the lab rat out of its cage.]

b. On Tuesday as well, <he didn't A take the lab rat out of its cage.>

(32) a. $[\![(31a)]\!]$ = [<u>in-cage</u>] ¬take-out

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⇝ Semantic identity up to Strawson-equivalence?

Over-generation:

(33) In the last election, Trump knew he was going to be elected president.
In this election as well, Δ although he has zero chances.

a. Δ = he knows he will be elected president.

b.# Δ = he believes he will be elected president.

Accommodation

A different argument: partial accommodation

[Romoli, 2011] notes that A wipes out all presuppositional content indiscriminately.

(34) $[\![\mathrm{A}]\!]\,([\underline{p'}]\,p) = []\,p' \wedge p$

But he argues that local accommodation can be selective:

(35) Either John stopped being upset that he also lost,
or John started being upset that he also lost.

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$\rightsquigarrow$ *John lost*	(from *upset that*)
$\rightsquigarrow$ *Someone else did as well*	(from *also*)
$\not\rightsquigarrow$ *John used to be upset …*	(from *started*)
$\not\rightsquigarrow$ *John didn't use to be upset …*	(from *stopped*)

(36) a. Either [A John stopped being upset that he also lost] or ...

b. $$[\![A]\!]\left(\left[\begin{array}{c}\underline{\text{J lost}}\\ \underline{\text{Someone else lost}}\\ \underline{\text{J was upset before}}\end{array}\right]\text{J isn't upset now}\right) =$$

J lost $\wedge$ Someone else lost $\wedge$ J was upset before $\wedge$ J isn't upset now

There is a problem, with an appropriately polymorphic generalization of A:

(37) Either [John [A stopped] being upset that he also lost] or ...

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(37) Either [John [A stopped] being upset that he also lost] or ...

(38) $[\![\mathrm{A}]\!]([\underline{V}]V') = \lambda p.\lambda x.\ []V(p)(x) \wedge V'(p)(x)$

We can rescue [Romoli, 2011]'s argument. Our proposal is to consider lexical items that carry "*two*" presuppositions and observe selective local accommodation.

(39) Amy doesn't notice that she is a legend.
$\rightsquigarrow$ *Amy is a legend*
$\rightsquigarrow$ *Amy is alive*

We can rescue [Romoli, 2011]'s argument. Our proposal is to consider lexical items that carry "*two*" presuppositions and observe selective local accommodation.

(39) Amy doesn't notice that she is a legend.
$\rightsquigarrow$ *Amy is a legend*
$\rightsquigarrow$ *Amy is alive*

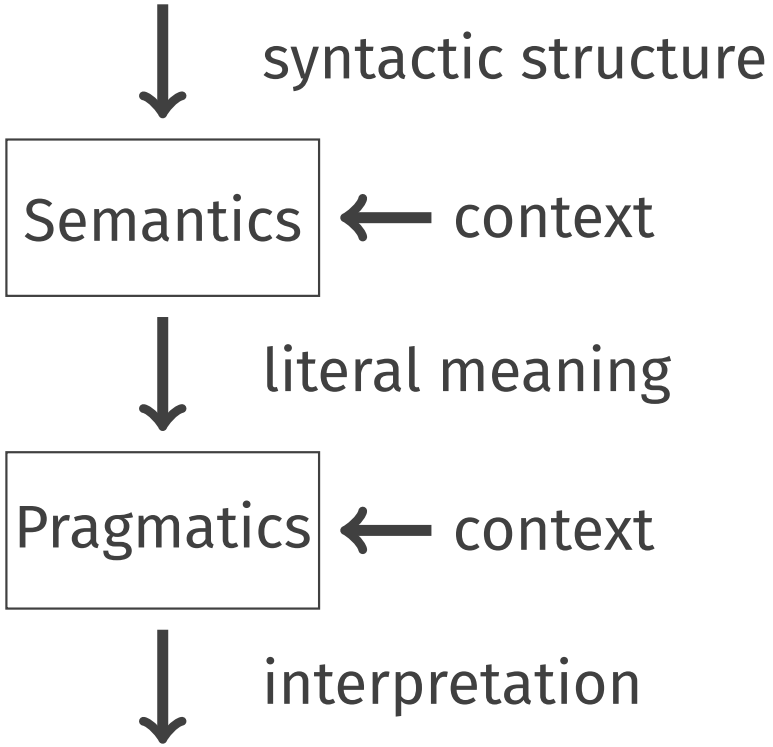
(40) Amy doesn't notice that she is a legend, because she's dead.
$\rightsquigarrow$ *Amy is a legend*

Recap

- Local accommodation isn't subject to the ellipsis parallelism requirements.
- Local accommodation is selective.
- Neither fact is compatible with the operator approach to local accommodation we consider.

Accommodation

Sketch of an alternative


syntactic structure
Semantics
context
literal meaning
Pragmatics
context
interpretation

Contextually-dependent expressions allows one to "*escape*" the parallelism requirement on ellipsis:

(41) Lila is convinced that the referee doesn't like her$_{=\text{Lila}}$.
And Maya doubts that the referee does <like her$_{=\text{Maya}}$>.

Contextually-dependent expressions allows one to "*escape*" the parallelism requirement on ellipsis:

(41) Lila is convinced that the referee doesn't like her$_{=\text{Lila}}$.
And Maya doubts that the referee does <like her$_{=\text{Maya}}$>.

(42) Lila λx. is convinced that the referee doesn't like x.
And Maya λx. doubts that the referee does <like x>.

(43) The dean at Harvard told every student $_{\text{at Harvard}}$ to leave.
The dean at MIT didn't <tell every student $_{\text{at MIT}}$ to leave>.

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The dean at MIT didn't <tell every student $_{\text{at MIT}}$ to leave>.

(44) The dean at Harvard λx. told every$_{C(x)}$ student to leave.
The dean at MIT λx. didn't <tell every$_{C(x)}$ student to leave>.

Assumptions (to be revised)

- A is always present
- It is parametric
- The parameter serve to turn it on or off.

(45) **A:** On Monday^x, Bill didn't take A_x the lab rat out of the cage.
B: On Tuesday^x too, <Bill didn't take A_x the lab rat out of the cage.>

(46) $[\![A_x]\!]^C([\underline{p'}]\,p) = [\underline{p'}]p$ if $C(x) = 1$
$[\![A_x]\!]^C([\underline{p'}]\,p) = []p' \wedge p$ if $C(x) = 0$

But A can depend on any kind of parameter!

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Assumptions (to be revised)

- A is always present
- It is parametric **on any value in the context**
- The parameter serve to turn accommodation on or off.

(47) $[\![\mathrm{A}]\!]^{C,g}([\underline{p'}]\,p) = [\underline{p'}]p$ if $C(g) = 1$

$[\![\mathrm{A}]\!]^{C,g}([\underline{p'}]\,p) = []p' \wedge p$ if $C(g) = 0$

What about selectivity?

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Assumptions (to be revised)

- A is always present
- It is parametric on any value in the context
- The parameter decides what is accommodated

(48) $[\![\mathrm{A}]\!]^{C,g}([\underline{p'}]\ p) = C(g) \wedge [\underline{p'}]p$

Given the assumed ubiquity of A, it no longer seems necessary to treat it as a syntactic operator.
$\rightsquigarrow$ *compositional approach*

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Generalized Contextual Restrictions

- The meaning of any constituent can be restricted.
- How strong the restriction is parametrized by context.

(49) $[\![X]\!]_{+}^{C,g} = [\![X]\!]^{g} \wedge C(g)$

Obvious concerns

- Can the meaning of *it rains* be restricted to mean *it rains and I'm eating shallops*?

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- Can the meaning of *it rains* be restricted to mean *it rains and I'm eating shallops*?
- Are presuppositions quantized?

(50) Amy didn't notice that she is a legend.

a. locally accommodate nothing

b. locally accommodate *she is a legend*

c. locally accommodate *she is alive*

d. locally accommodate *she is alive or a legend*?

Recap

- Local accommodation is not subject to the ellipsis parallellism requirement.
- It is selective.
- We suggest local accommodation be dealt with a contextual compositional approach.

Non-Redundancy inferences

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Non-Redundancy and *R*

[Blumberg and Goldstein, 2020] hope to unify a large family of inferences:

- Diversity inferences
- Ignorance inferences
- ~~Free Choice~~

(51) **Diversity inferences:** Attitude [p] $\rightsquigarrow I(p)$

a. I hope Ann won the medal.

b. I wonder whether Ann won the medal.

c. I want Ann to have won the medal.
$\rightsquigarrow$ *I don't know whether Ann won the medal*

(51) **Diversity inferences:** Attitude [p] $\rightsquigarrow I(p)$

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$\rightsquigarrow$ *I don't know whether Ann won the medal*

(52) **Ignorance inferences** Attitude [p or q] $\rightsquigarrow I(p) \wedge I(q)$

a. I believe that Ann or Sue won the medal.

b. I hope Ann or Sue won the medal.

c. I wonder whether (or not) Ann or Sue won the medal.

d. I want that Ann or Sue to have won the medal.
$\rightsquigarrow$ *I don't know whether Ann won the medal*
$\rightsquigarrow$ *I don't know whether Sue won the medal*

[Blumberg and Goldstein, 2020]'s observation: both classes of inference can intrude:

(53) a. Exactly 2 of the 4 detectives hope that Ann committed the crime.
The others are absolutely certain that it was Ann.

b. Exactly 2 of the 4 detectives believe that it was either Ann or Sue that committed the crime.
The others are absolutely certain that it was Ann.

R "*presupposes*" that its complement must be true and false in at least one world.

(54) $[\![\mathrm{R}]\!]^{\mathrm{LC},w}(p) = 1$ if $\exists v, v' \in \mathrm{LC},\ p(v) \neq p(v') \wedge p(w) = 1$
$[\![\mathrm{R}]\!]^{\mathrm{LC},w}(p) = 0$ if $\exists v, v' \in \mathrm{LC},\ p(v) \neq p(v') \wedge p(w) = 0$
$[\![\mathrm{R}]\!]^{\mathrm{LC},w}(p) = \#$ otherwise

(55) Bill hopes that R [Ann has won the medal]

a. LC = Bill's belief worlds in *w*

b. *Ann has won the medal* must be diverse in LC

By stipulation, attitude modals have belief worlds as their local contexts.

(56) *Bill believe [R Ann won the medal]

Contradiction Avoidance

Do not insert R if it yields a contradiction.

(57) Bill hopes that R_1 [Ann has won the medal] or R_2 [Sue has won the medal].

a. LC = Bill's belief worlds in *w*

b. p:="*Ann has won the medal*" must be diverse in LC (R_1)

c. "*Sue has won the medal*" must be diverse in LC ∩ ¬*p* (R_2)

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This entails the existence of:

- a world where Ann won the medal

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c. "*Sue has won the medal*" must be diverse in LC ∩ ¬*p* (R_2)

This entails the existence of:

- a world where Ann won the medal
- a world where Sue and not Ann won the medal

Non-Redundancy inferences

Diversity Inferences are lexical

These inferences should not receive a unified treatment, because diversity inferences are lexicalized.

(58) a. Is Bill wondering whether Ann got the medal?
$\nrightarrow$ *diversity*

b. Does Bill hope that Ann got the medal?
$\rightarrow$ *diversity*

These inferences should not receive a unified treatment, because diversity inferences are lexicalized.

(58) a. Is Bill wondering whether Ann got the medal?
$\nrightarrow$ *diversity*

b. Does Bill hope that Ann got the medal?
$\rightarrow$ *diversity*

(59) a. I live here because I want to live here.

b.# I live here because I hope to live here.

Simple-minded lexical account: verb heterogeneity explained by the arbitrariness of the lexicon.

(60) a. $[\![\text{hope}]\!]^{w_0}(p_{st})(x_e)$
$= [\underline{\exists w, w' \in \text{belief}(x)(w_0), p(w) \neq p(w')}]$
$\forall w \in \text{hope}(x)(w_0), p(w)$

b. $[\![\text{wonder whether}]\!]^{w_0}(p_{st})(x_e)$
$= \exists w, w' \in \text{belief}(x)(w_0), p(w) \neq p(w') \wedge \text{wonder}(p)$

For *hope*, the intrusion of diversity inference is just the intrusion of presupposition:

(61) Exactly 2 of the 4 detectives [$_C$ hope that Ann committed the crime].
The others are absolutely certain that it was Ann.

(**Alternative:** regular presupposition projection out of quantifiers)

Non-Redundancy inferences

Ignorance Inferences: ellipsis argument

A lexical treatment is difficult to argue for ignorance inferences:

(62) a. Bill believes I touched the left part of the wall or the right part.
$\rightsquigarrow$ *ignorance*

b. Bill believed I touched the wall.
$\not\rightsquigarrow$ *ignorance*

We can ask whether ellipsis preserves parallelism:

(63) **A:** The detective believes that it was Ann or Bill that committed the crime.
B: The lawyer doesn't.

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(63) **A:** The detective believes that it was Ann or Bill that committed the crime.
$\rightsquigarrow$ *ignorance*
B: The lawyer doesn't.
$\not\rightsquigarrow$ *denying ignorance*

We can ask whether ellipsis preserves parallelism:

(63) **A:** The detective believes that it was Ann or Bill that committed the crime.
B: The lawyer doesn't.

The detective believes [... R ...R ...].
I don't <... ∅... ∅...>.

Parallel reading do exist, but the main point is that they're not mandatory:

(64) **A:** The detective believes that it was Ann or Bill that committed the crime.
B: The lawyer doesn't. He's convinced Sue is guilty.

Non-Redundancy inferences

Sketch of an account

How to account for local readings of ignorance inferences while avoiding syntactization?

A Non-Triviality Pragmatic principle

Call LC the local context of a constituent X (of a t-ending type), relative to a context C. It ought to be the case:

- $\text{LC} \not\Rightarrow [\![X]\!]$
- $\text{LC} \not\Rightarrow \neg [\![X]\!]$

A Non-Triviality Pragmatic principle

Call LC the local context of a constituent X (of a t-ending type), relative to a context C. It ought to be the case:

- $\text{LC} \not\Rightarrow [\![X]\!]$
- $\text{LC} \not\Rightarrow \neg [\![X]\!]$

$\rightsquigarrow$ *It looks similar to R but is a much weaker principle*

(65) The detective believes that [Ann is the culprit.]$_X$

a. $\neg\forall w \in C, \forall w_0 \in B(\iota\text{detective}, w), \text{culprit}(w_0)(\text{Ann})$

b. $\neg\forall w \in C, \forall w_0 \in B(\iota\text{detective}, w), \neg\text{culprit}(w_0)(\text{Ann})$

(65) The detective believes that [Ann is the culprit.]$_X$

a. $\neg\forall w \in C, \forall w_0 \in B(\iota\text{detective}, w), \text{culprit}(w_0)(\text{Ann})$
$\rightsquigarrow$ *in some world of the context set, in some of the detective's belief worlds, Ann is not the culprit.*

b. $\neg\forall w \in C, \forall w_0 \in B(\iota\text{detective}, w), \neg\text{culprit}(w_0)(\text{Ann})$
$\rightsquigarrow$ *in some world of the context set, in some of the detective's belief worlds, Ann is the culprit.*

This, by itself, does not yield ignorance inferences:

(66) The detective believes that [Ann is the culprit]$_X$ or Sue is the culprit.

a. $\neg\forall w \in C, \forall w_0 \in B(\iota\text{detective}, w), \text{culprit}(w_0)(\text{Ann})$

b. $\neg\forall w \in C, \forall w_0 \in B(\iota\text{detective}, w), \neg\text{culprit}(w_0)(\text{Ann})$

It is observed that conditions of the form $\neg\forall w \in C$ are frequently strengthened to $\forall w \in C\neg$ [Chemla, 2008] (akin to *homogeneity* [Löbner, 2000])

(67) Josh believes that I have a sister.

a. $\rightsquigarrow$ *I don't have a sister*

b. **Predictions of MP:** *the context set does not entail I have a sister.*

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What about intrusion of ignorance inferences?

$\rightsquigarrow$ Local Accommodation!

...does it really make sense ? ...

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- For R, we proposed a non-triviality pragmatic principle and generalized restrictions for intrusions.

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